

STRUGGLE -- HEALTHY AND UNHEALTHY

Greetings, my dearest, dearest friends. God's blessings for each and every one of you. Love and strength are pouring forth. Open your hearts so that you may tune in to this force.

Not one of you ever has to encounter a difficulty he is not strong enough to surmount. Do not doubt the resources of strength that exist in your soul. Reach for these inner resources. This will give you strength rather than the dependency of receiving it from outside. Any kind of blessings and divine help of any kind are possible only through you, through your own strength that already exists in you, that lies dormant within yourself. It can never be added on to you. It is a force that flows from within -- never from the outside.

Depend on this inner strength that you have the power to liberate. Man so often reaches for outside strength, for outer intervention, while he has but to realize that nothing can come forth from life that he does not have the equipment with which to work and become thereby stronger and wiser. In this attitude, your self-confidence and self-respect will indeed be strengthened. While if you are helped outwardly, the help may momentarily be pleasant, but it will not increase your self-confidence, your self-reliance, your independence, your self-respect. So reach inside. Realize that the universal laws are made in such a way that nothing whatsoever could possibly be beyond your strength, beyond your capacities. If sometimes it seems so, it is only because you doubt or you ignore what resources exist in you.

So often man says that life is difficult and painful, that life is an ordeal, confusing and puzzling, that there is no meaning to it. His attitude and belief are as though he and life were two separate factors. They are not! Whatever life is for you, that you are yourself. Whatever your life appears to you is an exact facsimile of how you experience yourself. Your personal life, as it manifests for you, is a conglomeration of all your attitudes and traits. It is the greatest error possible, and one of the most fundamental ones, to believe that you are one thing and the life you are put into is another. This is not so. Whenever these words I am uttering now will have an inner meaning and reality for you, you will indeed have reached a stage of development when you no longer have to fear, when you are no longer a helpless straw in the wind. As long as you separate what your life is for you and what you are, you are not only in illusion, but, because of it, you are in fear and in disharmony. Such confidence as you have in yourself, in your capacities and potentials, the very same confidence will you have in life. The joy that exists in your heart, your ability to experience joy, that will be your life. As you experience the ability you have to cope with setbacks and disappointments, to relinquish your will if need be, so will the possibility that life will frighten you become less. It goes on all the way like this. Once you examine yourself and your life from this point of view, you will have taken a further step towards the unification and integration that is our goal.

I think this particular topic is bound to bring up a number of questions, provided you take the trouble of really pondering over it. So prepare your questions for the discussion of this lecture. It will be very helpful to raise all your doubts and confusions into consciousness.

Life, of course, also contains struggle. But as in everything else, there is healthy and constructive as well as an unhealthy and destructive struggle. Let us try to understand a little more about this. Various philosophies and religions ask that you "give up struggling"; this is a truth. But it is often misunderstood and applied as though it meant giving up, giving in, resigning, the nonassertion of rights, that you become passive and apathetic and thus no longer try to fulfill yourself and your goals. It leads to indifference and sloth, to stagnation and even masochism. It leads to the cruelty of not caring to better conditions that can be bettered -- in yourself and in the world around you.

Healthy struggle never exhausts your energies. It is never futile in principle although it does not always reap success in a direct manner. Healthy struggle is a component of relaxed activity and the ability to accept defeat; of well-defined aims with healthy underlying motivations; of being concerned with the issue itself rather than with using the issue to cover up hidden psychological deviations. In healthy struggle, you never fight against yourself. Overcoming impurities and immaturity does not mean struggling against oneself but, as you know, rather letting these aspects reach your surface awareness so that you can understand them and come to terms with them. This is the way to overcome what is disturbing and destructive, not by struggling against it.

Healthy struggle will make you forever stronger. In healthy struggle, you do not swim against the stream; hence it will not consume you and leave you depleted. It does not require effort or struggle to allow to the surface what is in you. In fact, man uses and wastes so much energy in preventing this, and then he wonders why he is so tired and, after having reached a certain age, why he no longer possesses sufficient energy to cope with the necessary struggle in life. If this energy current were reversed, life would become very different. With all his might, man struggles and fights against awareness of what is in him. He constantly stems the flow of his emotions. This is the unhealthy struggle. If only he would give it up, he could easily struggle where it is useful, meaningful, and productive. Whenever energy is used in its proper channel, it replenishes and regenerates itself automatically. But when it is used in a channel not destined for it, it certainly does not. So there is not enough energy left to defend yourself against being taken advantage of, to develop your potentials, to work towards your aims. All this is a natural by-product of ceasing the struggle against your hidden attitudes which you believe are eliminated by keeping yourself from being aware of them.

In healthy struggle, there is no anxiety, no fear, no uncertainty, no doubt. Whenever you struggle for an apparently healthy aim, but register any of these negative emotions, you can determine by this fact that unhealthy struggle must exist in some way. In some hidden way, you must struggle against yourself -- perhaps against a doubt or against selfishness or some attitude that hides a lack of integrity -- for otherwise these negative, depleting emotions could not be felt. This is the time when you must stop struggling against yourself and allow the stream of your hidden emotions to reach the surface.

All human attitudes, trends, and feelings can indeed be compared to streams. The stream that comes from inside out, and from outside in. It is a cycle in which inside and outside interact and

influence one another. But the controlling factor always lies in the self -- inside -- and never outside the self. In trying to shift the control by hoping and expecting damage to be repaired from the outside, by expecting help to readjust the inharmonious flow of the self and life to come from the outside, while simultaneously preventing the free flow through his struggle against awareness, man separates himself more and more from the real control he has at his disposal, the only meaningful control: complete awareness of the self.

When man does not like, or even fears, certain feelings and attitudes in himself, he blocks awareness of them. This amounts to barricading the stream that should flow freely. The essential idea in this analogy with the stream is not new, of course. But it requires ever new approaches and symbolic representations so that you can truly visualize the damage that is done by repression. You need new impetus so as to be newly inspired to remove the blocks and barricades. So, my friends, try actually to visualize each feeling, each emotion, each inner attitude and response as a stream. If you barricade a stream, what happens? It is possible to dam up a river or stream. The water will flow up to the dam and will then be stopped so that its flow does not continue beyond the dam. But the more the water accumulates behind the dam, the stronger the energy of the accumulating water will become until it bursts the dam, overflows, and destroys not only the dam itself but all the natural and healthy vegetation and structures alongside. To destroy the dam or barricade in such a violent way is not necessary. The dam never needs to be erected. But since it was, it has to go. You can make your own efforts in gradually and systematically removing it. This is the conscious process of self-confrontation. Waiting until nature takes its course -- against your will, as it were -- means that the barricade is swept away by the force of the waters. When life handles you roughly, when the accumulated destructive attitudes whose origins lie behind the barricade finally break loose, man experiences crises and breakdowns of different kinds and degrees.

By not damming up the river, the dirt and residue in it would freely float to the surface and be thus eliminated. The forever regenerating water, in its purity and freshness, will finally have the force to rid the river from the debris of a shipwreck. Is this not a fact in nature? The same applies to your soul currents. By fearing the debris of your past hurts and their subsequent destructive tendencies, you merely accumulate them behind the barricade where they are bound to swamp you one day when you cannot control what happens. But there will be nothing to fear when you merely allow this debris to reach the surface. That is why, when you begin to remove your blocks, you first experience predominantly negative emotions such as you had never consciously felt before. The temptation is then to put the lid on again. But beware of this temptation. The warm, positive, generous, loving, unselfish feelings must follow suit eventually. They will no longer be detrimental to you with the awareness of what exists in you anyway. Not wanting to see it does not eliminate its existence.

When you struggle against your inner insecurity by denying its existence, it mounts up behind the dam, like swelling waters. As long as the dam holds, you will feel a vague discomfort that you cannot place. You will feel inhibited without understanding why. You will sense that some of your best potentials are unutilized. But on the whole, you will not have a grasp of the situation, nor will you feel the full force of the existing insecurity that becomes stronger just because it mounts up behind the barricade. Then, one day, the measure will be full, which will take the shape of certain outer events that will swamp you with all the despair of the helplessness and insecurity that you had never dared to face. So you see, by struggling against your inner insecurity, you really increase it. By denying its existence, it gets bigger and stronger than it otherwise would. The same holds true of

any other emotion or attitude. Fear, doubt, hostility, whatever it may be, the principle is the same. It must be the same. The natural laws apply to all creation similarly for their sources and origins, whether they be material rivers or the rivers and streams of feeling.

Is it not much wiser and more beneficial to go about removing the barricade? Waiting until nature takes its course, for it to break down without your having a hand in it, will cause you to be helpless. The feelings will swamp you, but you will not understand their meaning and significance because the accumulated momentum has become too strong. Do not wait until such times. All too often, man waits until a crisis arises in his life before he is willing to take stock of himself.

It is our aim in this work to avoid the futile struggle; to remove the barricade before it removes itself; to allow the flow to bring out what is inherent in it; to see and to face those feelings that you would rather evade: the doubts, the aggression, the jealousy, the possessiveness, the self-centeredness, and self-importance -- in short, all that in you which is the child, the hurt child.

Why does man resist becoming aware of these emotions? When we speak of resistance, let us be very clear about what it really means. It does not merely indicate that you do not want this work. You would not mind this work if it would not require your removing the barricade of the stream. There is not just one stream in you. Since man consists of many attitudes and feelings, there are many streams. And a few of them, fortunately, are not barricaded. Those that are free create a healthy and constructive attitude towards yourself and towards your life. There are other streams where the barricade is not too strong. There, the resistance is not too difficult to overcome. But there are a number of "streams" which you have very deliberately cut off because you thought these to be a protection for you. When this work is started, the conscious self does not realize that this "forbidden area" has to be touched because the conscious self totally ignores the existence of these taboos. Only when the work approaches these areas, without your even knowing it consciously, will the resistance come forth. With some, this happens right at the beginning of their self-search. With others, the work may have well progressed for some time, and minor barricades may have been eliminated, freeing these particular "streams," while the "forbidden areas" are touched upon only much later.

The areas you do not wish to look at are not necessarily ugly or wicked in an extreme sense. In the final analysis, arrested growth is always life-defeating and self-centered. But the emphasis may not be on selfishness, but rather on false self-preservation. Put differently, it is a defense against exposure, hurt, and vulnerability.

The reason for stressing this topic at this particular time is because more and more of my friends need this understanding regardless of where they stand. It is of utmost importance to become aware and look at your own resistance. You will corroborate these words if you look at certain past stages from this point of view. You will then recall that every major liberation was always preceded by a resistance to looking into yourself, no matter what form this resistance may have taken. You always had to overcome it with the best of will, with summoning all your desire to look at yourself in truth. This had to be the strongest, the most important aim. Otherwise you cannot succeed. But do not for a moment believe that with these past efforts, you will not have to go through the same healthy struggle again: the struggle to overcome struggle against recognition.

Learn to discover the signs of such resistance to removal of the barricade. The signs may be manifold, but once you focus your attention on their existence you will not miss them. You will learn to take the seemingly legitimate excuses with a grain of salt.

If some of what I say here is repetition, it is necessary because some of my friends are now ready to understand and live these words in a far more vital way -- through your progress and increased understanding, not because you have read or listened to more lectures, but because you have more self-knowledge. Layers of your psyche that were closed up before are now accessible. Thus these words can now be utilized as they could not have been before.

The reason for resistance is not only because your ideal of yourself does not correspond to the reality you find beyond the barricade; nor is it sufficient to say that the barricade serves as a supposed defense against the hurts of life. This is too general. We need to have a more specific understanding about this. One aspect of the hidden reason for the barricade is that the psyche hopes against hope that the person can remain a child. To do so seems to have the advantage of being given what one needs to be happy and secure, of avoiding the effort of obtaining it oneself. This seems very tempting. The child is indeed entitled to just receive without making the effort to stand on his own feet. The recollection of this time combines with the afflicted areas of past hurts and the subsequent defenses against them. But this aspect of wishing to avoid effort has to be understood as a separate aspect. Because the psychic forces have tended in the direction of deliberate helplessness, the ego has remained weak and therefore cannot trust itself. This in turn furnishes a "reason" for depending for one's needs upon others. Man does not wish to give up the belief that happiness, fulfillment, security can come from others. He clings to this hope because this is what he would like. This is one of the main reasons for resisting removal of the barrier. By removing it, he will know that he clings to unjustified hope and that he does not wish to acknowledge this fact. He does not wish to go through all the effort of having to be responsible for his life. He does not want to shoulder the brunt of his failing in this respect up to now. To depend on others for one's needs may take many forms, may apply to many very different aspects of outer and inner life attitudes. In what respect this applies to you, you have to find out.

As a child is helpless, so is an invalid. They both depend on others. The resisting psyche is therefore not only the child that has not grown yet, but also a deliberate invalid. On the one hand, man is afraid of his helplessness and does not give himself the chance not to be helpless nor to test and see whether or not this be true. On the other hand, he is afraid of the very opposite -- that he is indeed not helpless, that he has many more resources than he likes to admit because that demands certain obligations and responsibilities towards himself. He rather assumes false responsibilities that are not his own because that seems so much easier, so much more laudable than assuming the responsibilities that are really his. This, too, can only be verified in subtle, hidden, specific areas and is not easy to determine without having gained considerable self-knowledge already.

To summarize, the prohibition against allowing the flow into your conscious mind is due to (a) fear of imperfection, (b) fear of having to shed means that supposedly protect one from hurts, (c) insistence on remaining a child because then others are responsible for his needs, his happiness, his safety. Again I have to admonish you that determining these aspects is not easy. Many emotions must have reached surface awareness already. If you persevere, you will come to find your fear of helplessness as you simultaneously fear your nonhelplessness. You fear the fact that you need not

be helpless if you do not wish to be. You also fear having to give up the childish desire for instant gratification of all your wishes.

These are resistances that cut you off from your life stream even if this life stream brings in its wake, to begin with, some debris. But is it not much better to let this debris flow freely where you can see it? And in seeing it, you have the means of removing it. Otherwise, it will build up behind the barricade as the water mounts and the debris gains momentum by the increased force of the cut off stream.

Recognize the signs of resistance, my friends! Observe yourself. See how you are always tempted to shove an unpleasant feeling away in the hope that it will thus "go away." Observe how you try to find easy explanations that do not really satisfy you. Observe how you make excuses for not looking at these disturbances, how everything else seems more important. Beware of the easy rationalizations, for they are the most dangerous ones. Rationalizations that are untrue and preposterous -- and they exist even with the sanest people -- are much easier to cope with because it requires less effort for truthfulness to penetrate the guise. But the seemingly valid ones, those require a most sincere effort and cultivation of truthfulness. They are the real dangers you must try to find in you. Each one of you, who is so ardently concerned with spiritual development, with inner growth, may pose the following questions: "What is most important for me and my life in order to reach the maximum self-honesty possible? Which of my activities help me most in this? Do I deceive myself when I wish to believe that any other activity but self-recognition can bring the spiritual development I wish? Is growth and development possible without it? Are my efforts in this respect sufficient, or could more be done? If more could be done than I am doing, why do I permit this? Could it be that I cultivate self-finding only in those areas that do not hurt, that do not create anxiety in me? If this is so, then I must consider that fact that I, too, resist knowing what is in me. What is my attitude towards myself in this admission? If I want to persist in my resistance, is it not better that, at least, I know that I lack the courage to look at myself, rather than pretend the opposite? Do I have the courage for this admission? Can I envisage that in certain areas of my being I am courageous and utterly willing to look truthfully at myself, while other areas may exist where the opposite holds true?" All these questions you should ask of yourself and listen very carefully into yourself. Pray that you should not wish to deceive yourself about these answers. If you do this, my friends, it will mean more than you can possibly believe at this time. Once these questions will really and truthfully be answered, you will also experience the difference between healthy and unhealthy struggle.

If there is doubt in you, and you do not wish to doubt, and you struggle against the doubt by denying its existence, you do not remove it. But this denying is exactly what your resistance, your barricade, does. It is a make-believe of not doubting; it is not a reality. Doubt is one of many emotions. There are clusters of negative emotions combined in certain attitudes you resist recognizing. Stop the resistance, let them float freely to the surface, and you have nothing to fear from them.

Unhealthy struggle is resistance. Both are futile because your fight is directed into making yourself believe what does not correspond to reality. It is as simple as that and is necessary to be recognized in these terms. Understandably, my friends tend to forget all this, and it is my task to see that they are reminded of it at appropriate times. It is my task to furnish them with the equipment

they need, part of which are reminders and strong visual examples that approach the same problem from a new angle.

So do not struggle against that which is in yourself, regardless of what it is. For in the struggle of denial, you consume your energies. You perpetuate self-deception, and you do not achieve the result you wish. Learn to accept the fact that you are only human and are not despicable because you harbor the same human weaknesses as all your fellow human beings. Thus you will be kinder towards yourself, and this in turn will enable you to face all that is in you. Harsh unkindness with oneself is not a virtue, my friends, as may so easily be believed. It is quite the opposite because it is proud, arrogant, and it breeds self-deception, untruthfulness.

Those of my friends who have moved upwards and have grown will surely hear something new and different in my words tonight even though there is no new idea as such presented in this lecture. I also want to remind you once again, whenever you feel inner discomfort, it is not sufficient to look for the deeper meaning as such, but also to see when you felt in a similar way when you were a child. Then synchronize these two feelings. But, again, it is necessary to have made some progress on this path before this is meaningful and liberating. Otherwise it will merely be an empty, although perhaps interesting, speculation. Do not ever forget that it is the childhood hurts that you have not yet come to mature terms with that cause you to barricade the stream; to resist; to be untruthful towards yourself; to be in destructive patterns and inner fear and insecurity. It is these that cause you to struggle in the wrong direction, which puts you into disharmony with the life flow, with the time flow. Only as you understand this, can you put yourself in the stream, to flow with the tide of time, space, and movement, to be in harmony with the universal forces. He who has never found and consciously acknowledged a resistance in himself, who believes that he does not have resistance, still has much to learn. He is way behind those who can freely admit, and thus cope with, their resistance.

If there is a spontaneous question regarding this lecture, please ask it now. There is sufficient material in this lecture to bring forth many other questions after you have meditated about it so that there should be enough material for the discussion.

QUESTION: If someone has repressed fear and then has come to realize it, and this realization then makes the fear overflow -- what you discussed today, that whenever there is an overflow, then there is a struggle. Could you please help and show how to cope with this?

ANSWER: It is an error to believe that just by allowing yourself to become aware of the fear, that this causes the overflow you cannot cope with. It is not the awareness that causes this difficulty of coping with the fear, but the attitude towards the existence of the fear and what lies underneath it. The wrong attitude is that a struggle against the fear exists, a struggle in the unhealthy way. If you struggle in the sense of "I should not be in fear, I do not want to have fear because it is unpleasant," it is a fight against part of yourself, against that part that happens to be in fear now. The feeling of being flooded by fear comes from bracing against the wave of fear even though your defenses against nonrecognition have been weakened, and parts of the fear stream penetrate in spite of the stemming against it. It is as though you have partly removed the barricade because of your realization that this cannot bring the development you aspire to, but only partly so. The other half bargains and wants to have the fear removed before it is fully out of hiding, with all its ramifications. If you stop stemming and struggling against the fear, if you can say, "I, a human being like many

others, am now in fear," you will finally float with the wave, you will rise on the wave rather than being immersed in the wave of fear. You will swim in the fear. This will eliminate the feeling of danger although the fear will still be present, but in a very different manner of experiencing it. Immersion is due to stemming against the wave, struggling against it. Swimming in it does not mean drowning; it is the opposite. The fear of drowning prevents a person from swimming although he has the perfect capacity to swim. Only then can you come to see what is behind the fear. The nagging, persisting, enduring fears are the unrealistic ones that you do not cope with properly, regardless of what the issue may be. Underneath these, you will always find some other "streams of emotions" that are blocked off from flowing. These other emotions may be manifold: hostility, humiliation, pride and shame, hurt, arrogance, self-importance, self-pity, insistence on unreasonable demands, and many more. Some of these other feelings are there but are struggled against as the fear was struggled against. Very often, the first layer to be found underneath the fear are strong hostilities that are particularly taboo. If they are allowed into the fresh air of consciousness, the fear will automatically cease. I promise this will be so, and this has often been corroborated by friends who have already gone through this phase.

QUESTION: And if it is not a psychological fear, but a physical fear?

ANSWER: The attitude towards a physical predicament does not preclude psychological deviations. A realistic fear will be coped with in the best and most reasonable way possible. If the unpleasant result one fears is not eliminated by these activities, then acceptance of the unpleasantness must finally come if it is coped with maturely and realistically. But this acceptance is impossible to attain so long as one struggles against the nonacceptance. The mind is being divided. Part of it says, "I should accept what cannot be altered." Another part says, "I do not want to accept it." Whenever real situations result in enduring, nagging, drawn out fear, this division exists and is not recognized. Moreover, the same underlying negative emotions are still kept in hiding. They simply make themselves known with a now real outer reason. But the existence of the outer reason does not eliminate their presence. The inevitable difficulties of life can be met only if the psychological deviations are recognized. If a real outer fear immerses you, then you struggle against you in life. And here we come around full circle to the beginning of this lecture.

Ask yourselves, my friends, if you are afraid of certain happenings in life, are you not doubtful of your strength and resourcefulness to go through with it? Tackle it from there. A final word regarding this, the doubt in your own resources has to do with your childish insistence of having to have your way; of your inability to relinquish, to stand not having your way. The more you must have, the more will you be in fear, and the more will you struggle against the knowledge of this fear and the knowledge of this childish insistence. The emotional maturity we seek to attain is the ability to tolerate frustration that everything does not always go one's own way. That will enable you to finally master yourself and life because you float with the wave instead of stemming against it. That alone will furnish you with self-confidence. If you can accept and live with not having what you want -- whatever it may be at any given time -- that will give you the trust in yourself that you truly deserve. If you must have what you want without being able to provide it for yourself, you will be helpless and dependent and insecure. If you can accept a frustration because you yourself were and are unable to obtain your desire, then you will have the confidence of knowing that you can cope with life. My dearest friends, ponder and meditate deeply about these last two sentences. You will then come to see that the event you fear is much less fearsome than your helpless dependency to "must have" what you want, to deny your own and life's limitations that make this impossible.

My dearest friends, be blessed all of you! May the strength and the love that is pouring forth not only fill you with courage that you have all you need within yourself in order to master any situation, but may this also give you the strength and wisdom as well as the inner willingness to really understand what I said tonight. For this would mean such a liberation for you! It would mean such a difference between living and only half living. You cannot do enough to ponder over this lecture. Whatever is obscure or flat and merely words, ask about it here at the period of discussion. Try to make it a live knowledge, to apply it to yourself personally rather than possess it intellectually. At the discussion, it is not only permissible but recommended that you bring your personal problems. In that way, you will not only help yourself but also others. Be blessed all of you. Receive our love and blessings. Do not fear, you have nothing to fear. Pursue this work, and you will become forever stronger, more creative, more harmonious with yourself and with your life. You will become more alive than you ever thought possible. Be in peace. Be in God!

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